

ENGLISH LANGUAGE PAPER 4

PART A Group Interaction

These letters to the editor appeared in a local newspaper:

What the 'door close' button in Hong Kong lifts reveals about selfish city

In every lift in Hong Kong, the lettering on the "door close" button is worn with overuse. I've even seen people close the door before selecting the floor they want. On many occasions, I've had people stare at me blankly with a finger firmly on the button as I raced across a lift lobby. Why does this happen? Just to save a few seconds?

I see this attitude of self-importance and selfishness in other parts of Hong Kong culture. It is rare to see people hold doors open, offer seats to the elderly or let people pass them on the pavement.

Perhaps we should remove all the "door close" buttons from lifts. It would give us an extra few seconds to consider others.

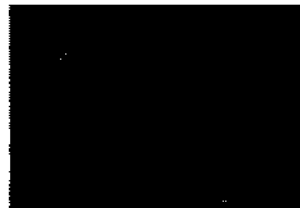
Peter Lok

I disagree with Peter Lok's logic in his July 27 letter. Why is there a door close button if we shouldn't use it? Is it there just to show we are polite because we do not press it?

Surely, if someone is in a position to press that button and does not press it, they are being rude. The button is there to be pushed, to save busy people many seconds at a time so they do not have to wait for the door to close automatically.

In the same way, if we hold the door open for everyone we will never get to work.

Judy Lai



Your class is working on a project about living in densely populated urban areas. Your group has been asked to discuss the two points of view expressed in the letters. You may want to talk about:

- which letter you agree with
- other situations when crowded places cause problems
- how to deal with these problems
- anything else you think is important

PART B Individual Response

1. Do you prefer to use the lift or stairs?
2. Are you often in a hurry?
3. What behaviour do you think is impolite?
4. Do you agree that young people today are polite?
5. Does living in a city make people less polite?
6. Do we need to teach politeness?
7. Why is being polite important?
8. Do ideas of politeness change over time?